

SAT READING & WRITING

Logical Vocabulary

Completing Texts with Precision — The Signal-Predict-Match Method

Instructor: Patrick Zou



Format: Demo Lesson (~15 min) | **Audience:** Parents & Students

 Print to PDF for best viewing (Cmd+P → Save as PDF)

1. What Are "Logical Vocabulary" Questions?

On the digital SAT, these questions ask students to **choose the most logical and precise word** to complete a short passage. Every passage contains a single blank — and the correct answer is the word that *best fits the logical structure* of the surrounding text.

The Core Challenge

The answer choices often include words students have *never seen before* (e.g., *paucity*, *stymie*, *sanguine*, *tenuous*). But here's the key: **you don't need to know every word — you need to know how to read the logic.**

The Question Format (Always the Same)

[A short passage of 2–4 sentences with one blank.]

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A) word A B) word B C) word C D) word D



On the Real SAT: These questions appear ~6–8 times per test. Each one is worth the same as a long reading passage question. Mastering them = easy points.

2. The 3-Step Method: Signal → Predict → Match

1 SIGNAL

Find the **logical signal word** in the passage. Is it contrast? Cause-effect? Illustration?

2 PREDICT

Before looking at the choices, **predict your own simple word** for the blank. What *kind* of word belongs there?

3 MATCH

Scan the choices for the word **closest in meaning** to your prediction. Eliminate wrong ones.



The Six Logical Signals

Every passage contains at least one of these logical relationships. Recognizing them instantly is the core skill.

Signal Type	Key Words	What It Tells You
① Contrast	but, however, although, while, despite, whereas, on the other hand	The blank opposes the other half of the sentence.
② Cause-Effect	because, since, therefore, thus, thereby, so, consequently	The blank is a cause or result of something else.
③ Restatement	: (colon) ; (semicolon) — (em dash), that is, in other words	The blank is re-explained right next to it.
④ Illustration	for example, for instance, such as, including	The example defines what the blank means.
⑤ Reinforcement	indeed, in fact, moreover, furthermore, not only...but also	The blank agrees with the other half (same direction).
⑥ Negation	not, never, far from, rather than, instead of	The blank is the opposite of what follows.

 **The Golden Rule:** You are NOT guessing the meaning of a hard word. You are using **logic** to predict what *must* go in the blank. The answer choices are just a matching exercise.

3. Walkthrough 1 — Easy EASY

Cuttlefish appear to be surprisingly _____ at exercising self-control: in a 2021 study conducted by behavioral ecologist Alexandra Schnell, these cephalopods **routinely demonstrated restraint** by delaying gratification, waiting for a favorite treat instead of instantly devouring a readily available meal.

Step	What I Teach Students to Do
① SIGNAL	The colon (:) is the signal — it means <i>restatement</i> . Everything after the colon explains what goes in the blank. 
② PREDICT	After the colon: " <i>routinely demonstrated restraint by delaying gratification</i> " → The cuttlefish are good at self-control. They're skilled at it. My prediction: "good" or "skilled"
③ MATCH	Which choice means "good/skilled at something"?

A) **imaginative** — creative, not "skilled"

✓ **B) competent** ← MATCH = capable, skilled ✓

C) **awkward** — clumsy (opposite direction!)

D) **manageable** — easy to handle, not "skilled"

✓ **Answer: B (competent)**

💬 **What I say to students:** "*You don't need to know the word 'competent.' The colon tells you the cuttlefish are good at something. Only B and D are positive — and D means 'easy to control,' which doesn't fit. B is the only one left.*"

4. Walkthrough 2 — Medium MEDIUM

The Polynesian languages, a group of related languages originating on islands in the Pacific, typically have _____ array of consonant sounds. For example, the Tokelauan language of the South Pacific has eleven consonants, and Olelo Hawai'i, the language of the Native Hawaiian people, has eight.

However, globally, the median number of consonants per language is over twenty-two.

Step	What I Teach Students to Do
① SIGNAL	"However" = contrast . The second half contradicts the first half. Second half: <i>"globally, the median is over 22"</i> → the global average is high .
② PREDICT	If the global average is high (22+), and "however" signals a contrast, then: Polynesian languages (11 and 8 consonants) have a small number of consonants. My prediction: "small" or "limited"
③ MATCH	Which choice means "small/limited"?



A) **musical** — not about size

B) **unvarying** — means "unchanging," not "small"

C) **exclusive** — means "restricted to a group," not "small"

✓ D) **modest** ← **MATCH** = small, humble in size ✓

✓ **Answer: D (modest)**

💬 **What I say to students:** *"11 and 8 versus 22. That's a small number compared to the global average. 'Modest' doesn't just mean 'humble personality' — it also means 'small in size or amount.' The contrast signal 'however' forces this meaning."*

5. Walkthrough 3 — Hard HARD

The 2023 anthology *The Big Book of Cyberpunk* contains 108 stories, including Fritz Leiber's "Coming Attraction" (1950) and Erica Satifka's "Act of Providence" (2021). With its chronological scope, it is more **comprehensive** than the much shorter 1986 cyberpunk anthology *Mirrorshades*, but *Mirrorshades*'s **careful selection** of stories makes that anthology more .

Step	What I Teach Students to Do	
① SIGNAL	"But" = contrast. First half: <i>Big Book</i> is comprehensive (includes lots of stories — quantity). "But" tells us that <i>Mirrorshades</i> has a different strength.	
② PREDICT	The clue after "but": " <i>careful selection of stories</i> ". Big Book = quantity (comprehensive). <i>Mirrorshades</i> = quality of selection . A book with careful selection is selective / thoughtfully chosen / showing good judgment . My prediction: "selective" or "well-chosen"	
③ MATCH	Which choice means "selective/thoughtfully chosen"?	

A) **capacious** — means "spacious, roomy" (synonym of comprehensive!)

B) **outmoded** — means "outdated" (wrong direction)

C) **cursorry** — means "superficial, hasty" (opposite of careful!)

✓ D) **discerning** ← MATCH = showing good judgment, selective ✓

⚠ **TRAP ALERT:** Option A ("capacious") is a trap! It means "spacious / roomy" — which is a **synonym of "comprehensive."** But the blank describes *Mirrorshades*, not *Big Book*. Students who misread which book the blank refers to will fall for A.

✓ **Answer: D (discerning)**

💬 **What I say to students:** "*Big Book* wins on quantity. *Mirrorshades* wins on quality — it carefully picks its stories. 'Discerning' means 'having good judgment in selection.' That's the exact contrast the sentence demands. And watch out for A — it's the #1 trap: a synonym for the **WRONG** book."

6. Walkthrough 4 — Advanced **HARD** (Vocabulary Trap)

Given that healthy genetic diversity supports honey bee population robustness — a matter of public interest given the bees' crucial role as pollinators of many crops, such as watermelon — a study revealing a _____ of diversity among US honey bees **raised concern**, though it also noted the potential to enhance the number of bees carrying several newly discovered genetic variants.

Step	What I Teach Students to Do
① SIGNAL	"Given that healthy genetic diversity supports...robustness" → diversity is good . A study revealing ____ of diversity "raised concern" → the blank must be something bad .
② PREDICT	If diversity is good, and the study "raised concern," then the blank must mean "lack" or "shortage" of diversity. My prediction: "lack" or "shortage"
③ MATCH	Which choice means "lack/shortage"?

✓ **A) paucity** ← **MATCH = scarcity, lack** ✓

B) **redundancy** — means "excess, duplication" (opposite direction!)

C) **disparity** — means "inequality, gap between groups" (not "lack")

D) **repository** — means "storage place, collection" (opposite direction!)

✓ **Answer: A (paucity)**

💬 **What I say to students:** *"You may have never seen the word 'paucity' before. That's fine. You know the sentence says 'lack.' Eliminate B and D — they're both positive. C ('disparity') is about inequality, not scarcity. A is the only one left. You just got the right answer to a hard SAT question without knowing the hardest word in the choices."*

7. Common Mistakes & How I Prevent Them

✗ Mistake 1: Reading the answer choices first.

"Students who read A/B/C/D before understanding the blank get biased. They try to 'hear which one sounds right.'"

✓ **My fix:** I train students to **cover the choices** until they've made their own prediction. Your brain can't be tricked by a word you haven't seen yet.

✗ Mistake 2: Translating into Chinese.

"When a student translates 'paucity' into 缺乏, they lose precision. 'Lack' in English has a different nuance than 缺乏 in Chinese, and SAT traps exploit this."

✓ **My fix:** I enforce **English-only prediction** in class. "What simple English word fits here?" — never "What's the Chinese translation?"

✗ Mistake 3: Ignoring the logical signal.

"Students treat the blank as an isolated vocabulary test. They miss the 'but' or 'however' that tells them the answer is the OPPOSITE of what they expect."

✓ **My fix:** I make students **circle the signal word** before doing anything else. If they can't name the logical relationship (contrast? cause? restatement?), they're not ready to pick an answer.

8. Summary — The One-Page Cheat Sheet

1 SIGNAL

Circle *but, however, because,*
colon, dash

2 PREDICT

Your own simple word. **Before**
seeing choices.

3 MATCH

Closest choice wins. Eliminate the
rest.

Quick Reference: Logical Signals

Signal	Logic	What the Blank Does
but, however, although, yet	Contrast	Opposes the other half
: ; — (restatement)	Explanation	Repeats what comes before/after

because, therefore, thereby	Cause-Effect	Is cause or result of context
for example, such as	Illustration	Defined by the example given
not, far from, rather than	Negation	Opposite of what follows



You don't need to know every word. You need to read the logic.

That's what I teach. That's what gets results.

